

Research Statement

Qilin Zhang

I am a macroeconomist who studies topics in public and family economics. I use microdata and quantitative models to study how households respond to institutions and public policy. China is the main setting for my research because its demographic and institutional changes raise direct questions about family decisions, public investment, and long-run economic outcomes. My current work focuses on marriage, parental investment, and the allocation of resources across generations. I also study local government debt and public finance.

Below I describe my job market paper, my work on local government debt, and ongoing projects.

Job market paper: gender-biased dynastic savings

My job market paper, “Gender-biased Dynastic Savings and the Marriage Market: Evidence from China,” asks why marriage is declining in China, where the crude marriage rate fell from 9.9 per 1,000 people in 2013 to 4.3 in 2024. Using the China Family Panel Studies, I document three facts. First, marriage sorts strongly on education, and single women are the most educated group. Second, parents invest more in daughters’ education at the margin: the income elasticity of education spending is 0.25 for daughters and 0.16 for sons. Third, parents save more for sons’ marriage: households with sons have higher saving rates, and the financial-asset share of sons’ parents falls by about 4 percentage points when the son marries.

These facts point to what I call gender-biased dynastic savings. Parents save for their children in two forms: education, and financial assets that the child brings into marriage. Two gender asymmetries shape how parents split their savings between the two. The technology that turns education spending into attainment differs by gender, and for daughters it varies with family resources. The marriage market sorts on education and expects husbands to bring assets. Parents of daughters therefore invest relatively more in education, and parents of sons relatively more in financial assets. Each family’s choice is individually optimal, but together the choices determine the education composition and relative asset positions of the next cohort, and with them how many compatible couples can form.

To quantify this mechanism, I build a model of one-child families that differ in parental resources and in the gender of the child. Altruistic parents allocate resources among their own consumption, education spending, and a premarital asset transfer. Children then enter a transferable-utility marriage market with idiosyncratic preferences, in which couples pool their assets, education enters the match surplus, and a norm penalizes husbands whose premarital assets fall short of their wives’. I estimate the education technology and the marriage surplus from CFPS data and calibrate the remaining parameters to the gender gap in the education–income elasticity, the saving-rate gap between sons’ and daughters’ households, and selection into marriage. Parents take the marriage market their children will face as given, so the counterfactuals are one-step experiments rather than a fixed point across generations.

Equalizing the education technology across genders raises the marriage rate by 0.62 percentage points through two opposing channels. More sons become highly educated, which lowers the marriage rate by 0.44 points. But the sons who remain low-educated enter the market with more premarital assets, which the norm rewards, and this raises it by 1.05 points. The gender gap therefore matters less through how much education sons receive than through which sons enter the market with few assets. Economic growth amplifies this force, because daughters’ education spending responds more to family income. As parents grow richer along China’s realized GDP path, the model’s marriage rate falls from 64.4 percent in 2010 to 52.3 percent in 2024, about 35 percent of the proportional decline in the crude marriage rate, and to 43.3 percent by 2035. Finally, transfers do not automatically raise marriage. A transfer equal to 20 percent of mean parental resources lowers the marriage rate by 8.73 percentage points when paid to parents, because it funds more education, and raises it by 14.22 points when paid to newlyweds. Where a policy lands in the family’s life cycle matters as much as its size.

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Public finance and local government debt

My second project is a solo-authored paper, “A Micro Anatomy of the Hidden Local Government Debt in China: 2014–2023,” presented at the 2025 Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting. The paper introduces a newly constructed dataset containing firm-level and city-level information on 2,940 industrial local government financing vehicles across 305 cities, compiled from public disclosures. The project is motivated by a basic public finance question: when formal fiscal resources are limited, how do local governments finance investment, and what are the consequences for the allocation of resources? The paper documents heterogeneity in hidden debt exposure across regions and sectors. It places local government debt in an institutional setting in which local governments have important responsibilities for investment and development but face constraints on ordinary-budget revenue. The dataset supports future work on the geography of off-balance-sheet debt, fiscal transparency, and debt sustainability.

Ongoing and future research

The next step for my job market paper is to close the intergenerational loop: a steady-state version of the model in which parents anticipate the marriage market their investments create, and in which the sex ratio and the provider norm evolve as women’s education rises. This would show whether gender-biased dynastic savings are self-reinforcing across generations.

In “Mass Layoffs and Fertility: Evidence from WARN-Based Shocks,” joint with Yuchen Zhu, I study how local labor-market shocks affect fertility. Using WARN mass-layoff notices linked to county-level natality data from 2020 to 2024, we examine how the timing and intensity of layoffs relate to subsequent fertility. Preliminary results suggest that larger layoff shocks are followed by higher fertility, with the response emerging about ten months after the shock and concentrated among large layoffs. Ongoing work examines the roles of the opportunity cost of time and maternal selection. In “Residential Mobility and Household Consumption,” joint with Yanqi Li, I study the relationship between residential mobility and household consumption using PSID data.

Across these projects, I begin with detailed microdata and use quantitative models when they help distinguish mechanisms or evaluate policy counterfactuals. I am interested in questions that matter both for academic research and for the decisions faced by households and policymakers.